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Canon's Price Philosophy

We spoke to Mr. Andrew Koh, Senior Director, Imaging Communication Product Group, Canon India about his responsibilities and his vision of Canon, India. He is from Singapore and is "married with three kids and one wife."

Swapnil Mathur

swapnil.mathur@thinkdigit.com

Q So the work you did in Singapore, and now being in India, do you feel there is a difference in how things work in terms of business and consumer behavior?

First and foremost, I've come from a very small country to a very huge country. In Singapore, the consumer is the same, but in India, consumer in the South is different from consumer in the North and they are different from the consumer in the East. The second thing that is very different is the level of familiarity with photography. I think Singapore is a very mature market for photographers, and this is based on the rate of adoption of newer technologies. India in my regards still has some way to go.

Q Since lenses are also a part of your division, we'd like to know how the prices of lenses are determined. Furthermore, what led to such a steep rise in their prices eight months ago?

Much as we try to standardize the prices worldwide, certain difficulties do come up, the first one being the exchange rate. When I first came to India in May, the Rupee was 55 against the dollar and now, it is 62. Since we cannot be changing prices all the time, we try to factor for this fluctuation. Second is the import duty, which is quite high on DSLR Lenses. The third is the VAT. Compare this to a country like Hong Kong, where there is no import duty or VAT, so lenses are cheap there. As far as the price hike is concerned, we are here for the long run and thus need to have a sustainable business. Therefore, we need to strike a balance between market share and sustainability. All these factors put together comes into play to determine the price of the lenses and even the price hike.



Andrew Koh, Senior Director, Imaging Communication Product Group, Canon India

Q What kind of signs should users look out for in terms of the price of equipment going up, so that they can decide whether to make the purchase now or wait?

Whenever people ask me when the best time to buy, my answer is always the same, "buy it now!" Why delay the gratification? The three or six months you spent waiting could have been spent enjoying the product instead! A product for us is not about the cheapest price, but the most value one can derive out of it.

Q Why does Canon India not offer an International Warranty?

Well, we at Canon try to provide our consumers with the best local experience. You buy it here and you will get the warranty here. There are cases like in Singapore where you can trade in our one year national warranty for a six month international one, but that's not so in India. As to why there is no international warranty, that is a Canon Inc. decision and I cannot comment on that. What we do have in India is the Canon Professional

Service (CPS) but we are currently in the process of revamping the requirements to standardize it across Asia. So you could travel across Asia and still reap the benefits of CPS.

Q Lately, the consumer has realized that big sensor makes a difference to image quality. What is Canon's take on that?

Well, we do have the large sensor GLx. However, different countries have different requirements. In the more developed countries, our S series is doing very well, and the G series is very popular. In India, not so much and I think that has to do with the level of sophistication and understanding of camera technologies, but I also believe that this is slowly changing. Earlier, people were only focused on one thing; "how many megapixels?" but after some time, they moved onto other things like sensor size and aperture. So overtime, I think that the understanding and sophistication will increase. I feel that as a market leader worldwide, we have a key role to play in educating the masses because we hold all the key technologies and we also manufacture all the parts and components ourselves.

Q What is your perception about the Indian market? Do you see the focus being primarily on point and shoot cameras or do you see a shifting trend?

The shift is definitely happening and it will develop a momentum overtime because a lot of people who have been focusing on compact cameras have suddenly realized that the demand for this category is declining, but the good thing is, that is driving up the demand for DSLR. This shift has already happened in many countries, but in India, it is just beginning.

Watch the interview at: <http://dgit.in/1h5faN1>